

View from Pakistan

THE ART OF WARINESS

Tough talk apart, Pakistan does not want to be seen jumping into talks that lead nowhere

Within Pakistan, there are few illusions about what the talks with India might achieve. While Pakistan has officially welcomed the “surprise” Indian offer to resume the dialogue broken off after the Mumbai attacks in 2008, most analysts see factors other than a sincere attempt to normalise relations. Many have commented that the “change of tone” in New Delhi indicates a belated recognition by India of the fail-

Mahmood Qureshi said publicly two days after the Indian offer was made. “We never kneeled before them and did not bow to their pressure.” Such rhetoric may indeed be meant primarily for domestic consumption, especially addressed to a public disillusioned by the lack of concrete progress in the previous dialogue, wary of alleged Indian involvement in insurgencies within Pakistan and still smarting from the IPL fiasco. However,

Basit told reporters the day the Indian offer was extended. Meanwhile army chief General Ashfaq Pervez Kayani has been talking bluntly about the threat to Pakistan and the region from India’s “Cold Start” war doctrine.

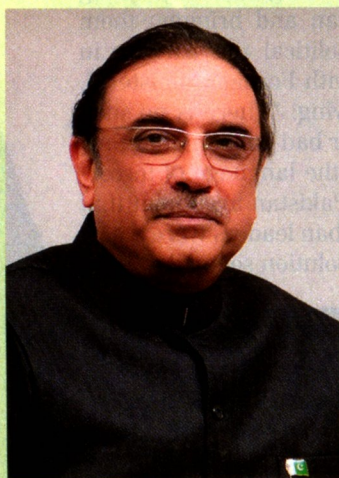
Of course, Pakistan’s hard-line stance is largely motivated by a perception that the West, particularly the US, needs its support for its new Afghanistan “stabilisation” strategy—involving a military surge as well as wooing of ‘moderate’ Taliban. General Kayani’s recent interaction in Brussels, with NATO in particular, has been termed extremely successful in conveying the need to take into consideration Pakistan’s concerns regarding its eastern border as well as anxiety about Indian involvement in Afghanistan. US special envoy Richard Holbrooke recently admitted that a major dilemma for the US in Afghanistan was to reconcile the conflicting security interests of India and Pakistan. The Americans would obviously like Pakistan to concentrate on the fight against the Taliban without being distracted by India.

For his part, Kayani has publicly stated that he supports normalisation of relations with India and seems to be on the same page as the civilian leadership. The Pakistan establishment, however, does not want to be seen to be over-eagerly railroaded into another round of inconclusive talks on issues close to its heart. Former ambassador Zafar Hilaly cautions that “discernible progress” needs to be made to avoid the risk of a backlash. “Frankly, it is better not to have any talks than for them to fail amid a welter of accusations,” he says. Overcoming the misgivings on both sides will not be an easy task.

by Hasan Zaidi in Karachi



AFP PHOTO/AMIR QURESHI



REUTERS/RAHEB HOMAVANDI

GENERAL
KAYANI
(EXTREME
LEFT) AND
ZARDARI

ure of the strategy of “limited engagement” with Pakistan, or in the words of *Dawn*, “the one-point agenda [India] has clung to since the Mumbai attacks”. However, some analysts have also drawn connections with the change in Western strategy in Afghanistan after the London Conference last month and credited the turnaround to arm-twisting by the US. In fact, Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani himself alluded to “international pressure” as being pivotal in bringing India back to the table.

As a result, Pakistani officials have been taking an unusually tough line. “India has come to us and sought talks,” Foreign Minister Shah

it is also meant to prevent dashing of any unrealistically high expectations.

At issue is India’s apparent desire to make counter-terrorism the centre-piece of the proposed talks. Pakistan has indicated it is only interested in a resumption of the “composite dialogue process”, which would mean terrorism being discussed along with a host of issues such as Kashmir, water rights, Siachen, Sir Creek and military build-ups. “We strongly believe that if India really dispenses with its traditional inflexibility on the Kashmir issue, there is possibility of moving ahead and resolving the dispute,” Pakistani Foreign Ministry spokesman Abdul